

60-Second Opening Template

Day 4 · Activity 3 handout. The opening you'll use to start tomorrow's negotiation. A good opening is **practiced, not improvised** — rehearse it aloud twice and time it. If it runs over 75 seconds, cut.

The four essential parts

Opening (target: 60 seconds)

1. ****Why we're meeting**** (1 sentence)
"I want to walk you through our proposed approach to <trade-off> and confirm that you can support it."
2. ****What's at stake for them**** (1 sentence in their currency)
"This affects <currency>: <one specific thing they care about>."
3. ****What you're asking for**** (1 sentence – concrete decision)
"I'm asking for <approval / specific information / specific action>."
4. ****Acknowledgment of any past tension**** (1 sentence; only if needed)
"I know last quarter's <X> didn't go the way we planned; I want to be sure we don't repeat that here."

Worked example — Compliance owner, async audit write

"Pat, I want to walk you through how we're timing the Reconcile audit writes and confirm you can support it. This touches the audit-trail timing your SOC 2 process leans on — events stay durable, they just land in the store within ten seconds instead of instantly. I'm asking for your sign-off that a ≤ 10 -second lag is acceptable, and a heads-up if any contract needs sync visibility. I know the retention change last quarter caught you late; I don't want a repeat, so I'm bringing this before we lock anything."

The bar for "good"

- **Under 75 seconds** when read aloud (time it).
- **Invites the stakeholder in** — it's not a lecture.
- **The ask is concrete** — a decision, not "thoughts welcome."
- The tension line, if used, is **honest and brief** — one sentence, then move on.

Rehearsal checklist

- ☐ Read aloud twice in the triad
- ☐ Timed — under 75 seconds
- ☐ The currency line names something *this* stakeholder actually cares about
- ☐ The ask is a single, concrete decision